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A SPY AMONG THE DERVISH

Spying looks good on screen. In the films, a lone wolf armed with a gun wages a global war against a strong army, pausing every once in a while to court a beautiful woman as a part of his cover.

But the reality is quite different. Some of the greatest coups in the world have taken place without a gun in sight. How do you engineer dissent among the members of a strong adversary? How do you court a friend turned foe to the best advantage of your country? How do you spot and recruit double agents to help your organisation get a ringside view of events on the other side of the fence? How do you change political dynamics in a certain region by playing off one country against another? And how do you unleash a shadowy war to bring in a favourable regime when your country's economic interests are at stake?

Vipul Chandra was the complete opposite of James Bond. The young spy was known as 'Santji' (saint) by his close friends and within the intelligence community. He was a teetotaller, had never smoked and had had just one love affair during his training period with a Mumbai-born girl he later married. Vipul's entry into the R&AW coincided with fast moving events on the global map including the Shia revolution in Iran headed by religious leader Ayatollah Khomeini, Soviet aggression in Afghanistan and the arrival of the USA in South Asia to arm a group of Afghan mujahideen. His first posting was at Kabul; eight months later, he was dispatched to Syria. Upon his return